

Seniors United Now

The Voice of Seniors in Alberta

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Dear Seniors United Now Members,

We here at SUN hope you are doing well and keeping safe during this time. Many things are changing in our world, and while the impact of the pandemic is being felt by all, we recognize that it has particular consequences for seniors. Not just due to the heightened health risks we as seniors encounter, but also the social and physical barriers that have come with the outbreak. We here at SUN are feeling the effects as well, there are many activities we cannot safely undertake, and even those we can, often take longer due to the numerous precautions that must be taken. However, rest assured that we are taking proper precautions, and we are continuing to advocate on behalf of Alberta seniors.

The World Health Organization's revised July 9, 2020 guidance indicates that the coronavirus can linger longer and travel farther in air than previously thought. Simple acts such as speaking loudly, singing, or even breathing heavily, after exertion for instance, can aerosolize the virus and lead to infections in individuals who are more than 2 meters apart in spaces such as offices or meeting rooms. With in person meetings possibly carrying significant risks, especially for seniors, it may be a considerable period before in person meetings can occur in relative safety.

We understand that seniors' issues are still arising, and there are still questions and answers SUN members have and want answers to. Therefore, we feel it is important to keep communication lines open with our membership, and where possible keep trying to answer those tough questions.

We know one area of concern and interest for some of our members is the advocacy for change with regards to the monthly deductions to pay back the coordination of pension benefits that were taken some years ago. This is a valid concern, and we feel it is appropriate to provide an update.

SUN has formally and informally contacted various support agencies, advocacy groups, and government areas, as the issues involved are not limited to our SUN membership. We recognize that the issue impacts many seniors throughout the province. And, as an advocacy group, our goal is to engage in discussions that lead to change, not just in the immediate circumstances, but also going forward with a goal to invoke change that has ongoing benefits for seniors in Alberta.

The stakeholders we have interacted with agree that this is an important issue, and that it must be dealt with. But, they universally agree that while this issue would generally have a high priority, in the current pandemic environment, that there are other higher priorities, such as the saving of lives in the province, addressing the financial strain caused by Covid-19, restarting the economy, and generally helping Albertans survive the crisis. Naturally, and generally appropriately, Government and organizations are focusing on these issues, and perceived lower priority issues, such as this, are not getting the high level of review and discussion we feel it would need to bring about change.



We have not, and will not forget about this issue, nor the urgency those impacted feel for this to be addressed. We are continuing to monitor the environment, political and otherwise. We want to ensure you that we are at the front of the line, when the current high priorities surrounding the pandemic wane, resulting in the likelihood of a more positive reception and fair hearing regarding change surrounding this issue. Short- and long-term change will require discussions between seniors, other agencies, LAPP, and the government. And they need to occur in an environment where these groups can focus on the issue at hand without the pandemic distractions that currently abound. In any case the Board of SUN will address the issue at their September meeting, and keep you informed of any progress.

Take care of yourself and each other.

Gordon Voth, President